

ENG508 SHORT HANDOUTS

MIDTERM

Lesson 11 to 15

(ENG508) Semantics and Pragmatics

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Lesson 11

PRESUPPOSITION

Topic 54: Introduction to Presupposition

What does presupposition mean in ordinary language?

Presupposition in ordinary language means to assume something.

How is presupposition defined in semantics?

Presupposition in semantics refers to assumptions implicitly made by speakers and listeners necessary for correct interpretation.

Topic 55: Two Approaches to Presupposition

How are sentences viewed in the first approach to presupposition?

In the first approach, sentences are viewed as external objects, and the process of producing them is not a concern.

What is the focus of the second approach to presupposition?

The second approach views sentences as the utterances of individuals engaged in a communication act, focusing on the strategies used in communication.

Topic 56: Presupposition Failure

What is presupposition failure?

Presupposition failure occurs when using a name or definite description presupposes the existence of the named or described entity.

In the case of presupposition failure, what happens when there is no referent for the nominal?

If there is no referent for the nominal, the sentences may be in a grey area, possibly neither true nor false.

Topic 57: Presupposition Triggers

What are presupposition triggers?

Presupposition triggers are types of presupposition produced by specific words or constructions, often derived from syntactic structures.

Give an example of a lexical trigger for presupposition.

Verbs like 'regret' and 'realize' are lexical triggers because they presuppose the truth of their complement clause.

Topic 58: Presupposition and Context

Why is there a problem for a simple truth-based account of presupposition?

Presuppositional behavior appears sensitive to context, creating challenges for a simple truth-based account.

What is defeasibility in the context of presupposition?

Defeasibility is the characteristic of presupposition where it can be canceled by general knowledge or context, as seen in example 2 with the verb "died."

Lesson 12

SENTENCE SEMANTICS - I: SITUATIONS

Topic 59: Introduction to Classifying Situations

How does language allow the classification of situations?

Language classifies situations through semantic distinctions of actions, states, processes, tenses, and aspects.

What are two common types of situations based on lexical categories in verbs?

Two common types are stative (e.g., knows, thinks) and dynamic (e.g., eat, drive) situations.

Topic 60: Tense and Aspect

What does tense allow a speaker to relate situations to?

Tense allows a speaker to relate situations to time.

How does the aspect system relate to events?

The aspect system allows the speaker to view an event in various ways, such as complete or incomplete.

Topic 61: Modality

What is modality, and how does it modify the meaning of an event?

Modality is a linguistic category that modifies the meaning of an event, expressing ways to "influence" the event, including giving permission, describing ability, suggesting, etc.

What are the two types of modality?

Epistemic Modality (degree of knowledge) and Deontic Modality (attitude to social factors of obligation, responsibility, and permission).

Topic 62: Mood

What is mood in the context of verbs?

Mood is the quality of a verb that conveys a writer's attitude or feelings towards a subject.

Provide examples of different types of moods.

Indicative moods: express facts, opinions, or questions based on realist form.

Potential moods: indicate probability.

Subjunctive moods: used for wishes, beliefs, exhortations, etc.

Imperative moods: make direct commands or requests.

Topic 63: Evidentiality

What is evidentiality, and what does it communicate?

Evidentiality is a semantic category allowing a speaker to communicate their attitude to the source of information, indicating whether it relies on personal first-hand knowledge or another source.

Name different types of evidentiality.

Witness Evidentiality: information from direct observation.

Sensory Evidentiality: speaker's evidence from sensory experience.

Inferential Evidentiality: statement based on deduction from facts.

Reportative Evidentiality: information reported by another person.

Assumed Evidentiality: information based on general knowledge or habitual activities.

Lesson 13

SENTENCE SEMANTICS - II: PARTICIPANTS

Topic 64: Introduction: Classifying Participants

What are some semantic labels for roles in linguistics?

Participant roles (Allan, 1986)

Deep semantic cases (Fillmore, 1968)

Semantic roles (Givon, 1990)

Thematic roles (Dowty, 1991; Jackendoff, 1990)

What is the distinction between grammatical relations and semantic roles?

Grammatical relations are morphosyntactic.

Semantic roles (e.g., agent, patient) are conceptual notions.

Topic 65: Thematic Roles – I (Agent, Patient, Theme, Experiencer)

Define 'Agent' in thematic roles.

The initiator of an action with volition.

Provide an example of 'Patient' in thematic roles.

John cut down these bushes.

Explain the concept of 'Theme' in thematic roles.

Entity changed or moved by a verb's action.

Define 'Experiencer' in thematic roles.

Entity aware of the action or state but not in control.

Topic 66: Thematic Roles – II (Beneficiary, Instrument, Location, Goal, Source, Stimulus)

What is the role of 'Beneficiary' in thematic roles?

Entity for whose benefit an action was performed.

Define 'Instrument' in thematic roles with an example.

Means by which an action is performed (e.g., writing a letter with a pen).

Explain the concept of 'Location' in thematic roles.

Place where something is situated or has occurred.

Define 'Goal' in thematic roles with an example.

Entity towards which something is moved (e.g., handing a license to the policeman).

What is the role of 'Stimulus' in thematic roles?

Entity causing a psychological effect during an experience.

Topic 67: Identifying Thematic Roles

Differentiate between 'Agent' and 'Actor' in thematic roles.

'Agent' displays volition; 'Actor' performs, effects, or controls a situation.

How is 'Patient' different from 'Theme'?

'Patient' is acted upon and changed; 'Theme' is moved but unchanged constitutionally.

Provide examples illustrating the difference between 'Patient' and 'Theme'.

E.g., Awais shattered the rock (Patient). Awais threw the rock (Theme).

Topic 68: Problems with Thematic Roles

What is the first problem associated with thematic roles?

Delimiting specific roles, especially in extreme cases like individual roles for each verb.

How does Dowty (1991) propose to address the problem of defining theta-roles?

Theta-roles are not semantic primitives but are defined in terms of entailment of the predicate.

Lesson 14

SEMANTICS AND GRAMMAR

Topic 69: Formal Grammar

Define formal grammar according to the Cambridge Dictionary.

Study or use of rules about how words change form and combine to express meaning.

What was the traditional assumption about grammatical categories?

Grammatical categories were assumed to be essentially semantic.

How did some linguists argue for the separation of grammar from semantics?

Grammar must be distinct from semantics, and categories must be wholly defined in terms of the form of language.

Give an example of a grammatical fact about English related to meaning and form.

'Man' /mæn/ is singular, and 'Men' /men/ is plural, conveying meaning differently.

Topic 70: Grammatical Categories

What does grammar encompass beyond form or function words?

Categories such as tense, gender, number, and syntactic functions like subject and object.

According to Palmer, what are two familiar grammatical categories?

'Gender' and 'Number,' although English strictly has no grammatical gender.

Explain the concept of noun class in grammatical categories.

Count nouns (e.g., a cat) and mass nouns (e.g., some butter) with examples.

How is the category of person associated with language forms?

Person (first, second, third) is linked to number and gender in verbal forms.

Topic 71: Grammar and Lexicon

Why is it irrelevant for semantics how a grammatical category is indicated?

Whether by word form, morpheme, or word order, semantics is not affected.

Distinguish between 'Grammar and Lexicon' using an example.

A sentence can be grammatically correct but lexically deviant, as seen in Chomsky's example.

Topic 72: Grammatical Relations

How are grammatical categories like verb, tense, etc., linked in a sentence?

A small alteration in their order can completely change the sentence's meaning.

What is the term for verbs that have objects and those without objects?

Transitive verbs (e.g., He ate food) and intransitive verbs (e.g., He laughed).

Explain the concept of causitivity in relation to transitivity.

Causitivity is closely related to transitivity, where an actor becomes the reason for an action.

Topic 73: Case Grammar

Define Case Grammar according to Collins Dictionary Online.

A grammatical description based on functional relations of noun groups to the main verb.

List three cases suggested by Palmer in Case Grammar.

Agentive, Instrumental, Object.

How many cases did Fillmore suggest in Case Grammar?

Six cases: Agentive, Instrumental, Dative, Factitive, Locative, Objective.

Lesson 15

FORMAL SEMANTICS TODAY

Topic 74: Diversity within Formal Semantics

What is one of the most popular tools for representing diversity within semantics?

Possible Worlds.

Explain Model-Theoretic Semantics and its basis.

Model is based on what reality is like for semantic purposes, defining truth-conditions in terms of a model of reality.

How do Davidsonian Semanticists approach semantics without possible worlds?

They express truth-conditions directly without relying on possible worlds.

What does a semanticist mean when referring to 'situations'?

A partial reality or model of reality less than a complete possible world.

Topic 75: Relationships with other Varieties of Semantics

What does formal semantics relate to among other varieties of semantics?

Semiotics, reference, lexicology, etc.

Are all semanticists formal semanticists?

No, not all semanticists accept the formal semantic commitment to truth-conditional meaning.

What is the importance of sharing ideas at the individual linguistic topic level?

Avoiding duplication of effort and mistakes, and synthesizing apparently incompatible ideas.

Topic 76: Relationship with other Fields

Which intellectual areas does formal semantics make the closest relation with?

Syntax, Pragmatics, and the Philosophy of language.

How is formal semantics connected to logic, computer science, and cognitive science?

Linked with logic for characterizing valid reasoning, with computer science for both intellectual and practical reasons, and with cognitive science for understanding the human mind.

Topic 77: Semantics and Society - I

List and briefly explain Leech's five functions of language in society.

Informational Function (linked with subject matter), Expressive Function (expressing feelings), Directive Function (influencing behavior or attitudes), Aesthetic Function (poetic expressions), Phatic Function (keeping communication lines open).

Topic 78: Semantics and Society - II

What is the associative meaning of an expression according to Leech?

It has to do with individual mental understandings of the speaker.

What dangers can arise from conveying attitudes and emotions through associative meanings?

Misconception and misunderstanding (varying meanings) and dominance of affective meaning over conceptual meaning.

Explain the concept of euphemism and its use in language.

Referring to something offensive or indelicate in terms that make it sound more pleasant or becoming than it really is. Also used positively in advertising as associative engineering.

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